

Photonic Integrated Circuits

Silicon Microring Resonator Study

Guilherme Lorete Schmidt

October 2026

1 Introduction

Silicon photonics has become one of the most promising photonic integration platforms in the last years. This can be attributed to its high index contrast and to the capacity to leverage commercial complementary metal-oxide semiconductor (CMOS) fabrication infrastructure to implement integrated photonic circuits (PICs) [1]. This permits fabrication companies to focus on the process developments while design companies focus on the technical design and applications [2].

One interesting technology developed in this context and applicable to wavelength division multiplexing (WDM) are micro-ring resonators. WDM is necessary to scale up the capacity in optical communications and interconnects, it is critical to implement robust low-cost silicon photonic WDM transmitters and receivers [2].

Therefore, this project aims to study how to dimension a micro-ring resonator for WDM applications based on performance requirements and fabrication process limitations.

2 Physical Description

In principle, a ring resonator consists of a looped optical waveguide and a coupling mechanism to access the loop. When the waves in the loop build up a round trip phase shift that equals an integer times 2π, the waves interfere constructively and the cavity is in resonance [3].

Thus, to describe the resonance condition of this cavity, we must characterize how light propagates in this dielectric optic waveguide. First, to confine the light inside the waveguide with total internal reflection, the refractive index of the core must be higher than that of the cladding. Si is commonly used in the core, since it has $n = 3.47$ at $\lambda = 1550$ nm, and silica in the cladding, with $n = 1.45$. Additionally, well chosen cross-section dimensions are essential to permit single-mode operation.

The vectorial wave equations that describe the field in the waveguide will be solved here through the effective index method (EIM), which gives a good working approximation. It consists in solving successive approximations of a two-dimensional (2D) rectangular waveguide by one-dimensional (1D) slab waveguides, which can be separately analyzed.

This gives as a set of wave equations for TE and TM polarizations which can be solved to determine the effective index n_{eff}.

Due to dispersion effects, the parameter used to quantify the total dependence of the effective index on wavelength is the group index, which is defined as:

$$n_g = n_{eff} - \lambda_0 \frac{\partial n_{eff}}{\partial \lambda} \tag{1}$$

For an accurate determination of the modes and bending loss in a 3D bent waveguide, however, we must resort to a full-vectorial analysis, requiring a numerical solution of the vector wave equation, which is typically formulated in a local cylindrical coordinate system [4]. Many commercial software can use FDTD or eigenmode solvers to calculate the group index from the given geometry of the ring and the desired operating wavelength.

In this study, we will be adopting the add-drop ring resonator configuration, shown in figure 1.

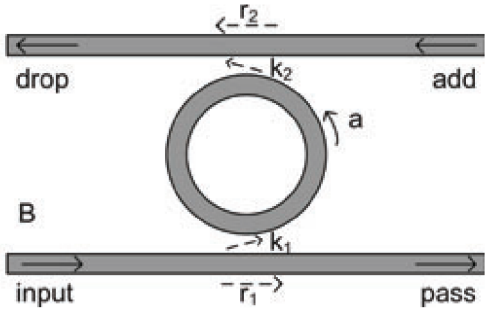


Figure 1: Add-drop ring resonator configuration. Source: [3]

An important factor to determine now is the coupling between the ring and the straight waveguides that have the input and output signals. Figure 2 presents a model of the edge-to-edge separations between the waveguides. The separation s is then given by equation 2.

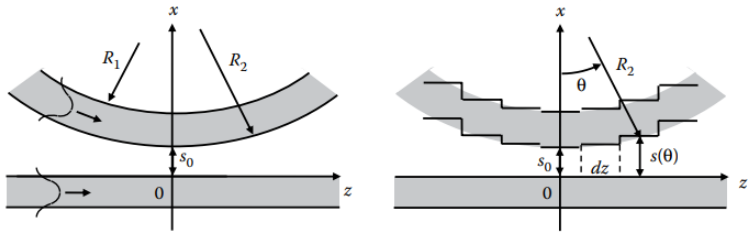


Figure 2: Bent waveguide model for coupling calculations. Source: [4].

$$s(\theta) = s_0 + R_2(1 - \cos\theta) \tag{2}$$

And, $k_c(s)$ being the coupling strength between two straight waveguides separated by a gap s, the total field coupling between the waveguides will be:

$$k = \int_{-\pi/2}^{\pi/2} k_c(s) R_2 \cos\theta \, \mathrm{d}\theta \tag{3}$$

Given these cross-coupling field amplitudes, the power spectral responses at the drop port and through port can be obtained as ($\phi_{rt} = 2\pi\beta R$ is the roundtrip phase and $a_{rt} = e^{-\alpha\pi R}$ is the roundtrip field attenuation factor) [4]:

$$T_d = \frac{a_{rt} k_1^2 k_2^2}{1 + a_{rt} r_1^2 r_2^2 - 2 a_{rt} r_1 r_2 \cos\phi} \tag{4}$$

$$T_t = \frac{r_1^2 + a_{rt}^2 r_2^2 - 2 a_{rt} r_1 r_2 \cos\phi_{rt}}{1 + a_{rt} r_1^2 r_2^2 - 2 a_{rt} r_1 r_2 \cos\phi_{rt}} \tag{5}$$

Observe that r_1 and r_2 are the field self-coupling coefficients.

If the attenuation is negligible ($a \approx 1$), critical coupling occurs at symmetric coupling ($k_1 = k_2$). For a lossy resonator, critical coupling occurs when the losses match the coupling as $r_2 a = r_1$ [3]. This condition ensures zero through-port transmission at resonance.

Observing these equations, we can see that wavelengths for which the roundtrip phase is a multiple of 2π will have a response peak in the drop port and a valley in the through port [5].

The distance between two of these resonances is called free spectral range (FSR) and is given by:

$$FSR = \frac{\lambda^2}{2\pi R n_g} \tag{6}$$

Therefore, a lower ring radius is interesting in the sense that it leads to a higher FSR. However, we must consider that a smaller radius leads to higher losses in the waveguide [3].

Another important expression we can derive for the add-drop ring resonator is the full width at half maximum (FWHM), related to the sharpness of the filter. It is given by:

$$FWHM = \frac{(1 - r_1 r_2 a)\lambda_{res}^2}{\pi n_g (2\pi R)\sqrt{r_1 r_2 a}} \tag{7}$$

Related relevant metrics are finesse and Q-factor:

$$Finesse = \frac{FSR}{FWHM} \tag{8}$$

$$Q = \frac{\lambda_{res}}{FWHM} \tag{9}$$

3 Design

To comply with the single-mode condition at $\lambda = 1.55\ \mu m$, the cross section dimensions of the ring waveguide are generally on the sub-micrometer range. The height is commonly in the 200 to 300 nm range and the width varies between 400 and 500 nm for SOI waveguides [3].

As a known example, we will consider a waveguide with 220 nm height and 450 nm width with an Si core and a SiO_2 cladding, which has a group index of $n_g \approx 4.3$ for $\lambda = 1.55\ \mu m$ [3]. We can then choose a 10 μm bending radius, which will already have $FSR = 8.9$ nm (or 1.1 THz). We could, for example, fit five 200 GHz channels in this range. The group and effective indexes should ideally be recalculated after each change in the ring radius, but they will be neglected in this analysis.

Then, the radius can be adjusted in a few tens of nanometers to choose the desired resonant wavelength ($\lambda_{res} = 2\pi R n_{eff}/m$). Note that the resonance wavelength of the ring is very sensitive to deviations in the fabrication process. A 1 nm deviation in width can lead to a 0.8 nm deviation in the resonance wavelength. Thus, an integrated heater deposited near the ring waveguide to permit active tuning of the resonant wavelength through the thermo-optic effect and thermal expansion. It allows large wavelength tunability, which can compensate the resonance variations from both fabrication and environmental temperature fluctuations [2].

Now, we should choose the gap between the waveguides in the coupling region seeking to maximize the on-resonance drop transmission subject to the required passband width and out-of-band rejection.

Figure 3 shows the power spectral response on the drop and through ports of the microring resonator modeled in this section. We may observe that the FSR agrees with the expected value and that the drop port has a reasonably good frequency selectivity. However, the passband lacks uniformity and may distort large bandwidth signals.

Through a sequence of ring resonators where each ring acts as a filter for a different wavelength, a mux/demux for WDM can be built.

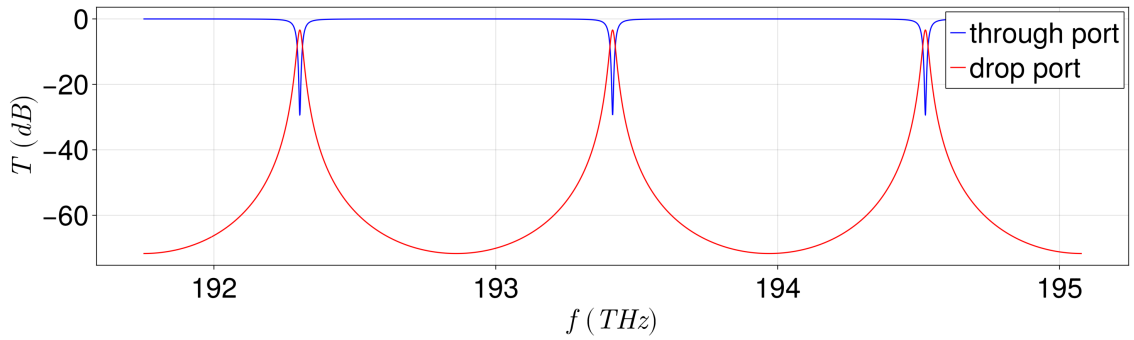


Figure 3: Power spectral response of the modeled ring resonator.

4 Conclusion

Although highly sensible to fabrication defects and environmental changes, microring resonators can play a useful role as spectral filters for communication purposes to multiplex or demultiplex WDM signals.

References

[1] Andy Eu-Jin Lim, Tsung-Yang Liow, Junfeng Song, Chao Li, Qing Fang, Xiaoguang Tu, Ning Duan, Kok Kiong Chen, Roger Poh Cher Tern, Chuan Peng, et al. Path to silicon photonics commercialization: 25 gb/s platform development in a cmos manufacturing foundry line. In *OFC 2014*, pages 1–3. IEEE, 2014.

[2] Po Dong. Silicon photonic integrated circuits for wavelength-division multiplexing applications. *IEEE Journal of Selected Topics in Quantum Electronics*, 22(6):370–378, 2016.

[3] Wim Bogaerts, Peter De Heyn, Thomas Van Vaerenbergh, Katrien De Vos, Shankar Kumar Selvaraja, Tom Claes, Pieter Dumon, Peter Bienstman, Dries Van Thourhout, and Roel Baets. Silicon microring resonators. *Laser & photonics reviews*, 6(1):47–73, 2012.

[4] Vien Van. *Optical microring resonators: theory, techniques, and applications*. CRC Press, 2016.

[5] Yash R Bawankar and Anamika Singh. Microring resonators based applications in silicon photonics-a review. In *2021 5th conference on information and communication technology (CICT)*, pages 1–6. IEEE, 2021.